

The Pit and the Pendulum

Edgar Allan Poe · 1842

First published: The Gift for 1843 (1842)

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Pit_and_the_Pendulum (revision 14833577), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Pit and the Pendulum suggest about terror and endurance?
- What does The Pit and the Pendulum suggest about the mind under torture?
- What does The Pit and the Pendulum suggest about rescue and hope?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Pit and the Pendulum	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*terror and endurance* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Pit and the Pendulum

Focus: reason struggling against terror

Content note (torture, rats): Sensitive content: Torture; rats. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes torture; rats.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Condemned by the Spanish Inquisition in Toledo, the narrator wakes in a pitch-dark cell. He narrowly avoids falling into a central pit, then wakes strapped beneath a razor-edged pendulum descending toward his heart. He smears food on his bonds so rats chew them free. The walls then glow red-hot and close in, forcing him toward the pit, until a French army takes Toledo and General Lasalle catches his arm.

Background: The Spanish Inquisition was ended by Napoleon's forces in 1808, and French troops did occupy Toledo. Poe's details are invented gothic horror, not history.

Significance: It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes torture; rats.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are avalanche, charnel, dungeons, wrestled, enkindled. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!" In this sentence it means: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Pit and the Pendulum would have known. The Spanish Inquisition was ended by Napoleon's forces in 1808, and French troops did occupy Toledo. Poe's details are invented gothic horror, not history. Why does this story matter? It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for imagery.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Very suddenly there came back to my soul motion and sound—the tumultuous motion of the heart, and, in my ears, the sound of its beating." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to reason struggling against terror? I circle "tingling", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find imagery, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for imagery.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of imagery. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Very suddenly there came back to my soul motion and sound—the tumultuous motion of the heart, and, in my ears, the sound of its beating. Then a pause in which all is blank. Then again sound, and motion, and touch—a tingling sensation pervading my frame. Then the mere consciousness of existence, without thought —a condition which lasted long. Then, very suddenly, thought, and shuddering terror, and earnest endeavor to comprehend my true state. Then a strong desire to lapse into insensibility. Then a rushing revival of soul and a successful effort to move. And now a full memory of the trial, of the judges, of the sable draperies, of the sentence, of the sickness, of the swoon. Then entire forgetfulness of all that followed; of all that a later day and much earnestness of endeavor have enabled me vaguely to recall.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Imagery, Structure, Point of view: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Pit and the Pendulum develops the idea of reason struggling against terror. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to terror and endurance? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about reason struggling against terror, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how imagery shapes reason struggling against terror. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
avalanche (noun)	a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain	*I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
charnel (noun)	a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited	*The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dungeons (noun)	dark underground prison cells	*Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
wrestled (verb)	combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force	*At length it forced—it wrestled its way into my soul—it burned itself in upon my shuddering reason.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
enkindled (verb)	cause to start burning	*The glare from the enkindled roof illumined its inmost recesses.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tingling (verb)	prickling or stinging slightly	*Then again sound, and motion, and touch—a tingling sensation pervading my frame.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
torrents (noun)	a heavy rain	*A fearful idea now suddenly drove the blood in torrents upon my heart, and for a brief period, I once more relapsed into insensibility.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
encompassed (verb)	surrounded	*The blackness of eternal night encompassed me.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ascertaining (verb)	finding out for certain	*This process, however, afforded me no means of ascertaining the dimensions of my dungeon; as I might make its circuit, and return to the point whence I set out, without being aware of the fact; so perfectly uniform seemed the wall.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cessation (noun)	a stopping	*At first, the ravenous animals were startled and terrified at the change—at the cessation of movement.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly?
2. Where does imagery appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with terror and endurance?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who has condemned the narrator? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The Inquisition
2. How does the narrator first discover the pit? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He trips and falls with his face at its edge
3. How does he escape the pendulum? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them
4. What do the walls do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Glow red-hot and close in
5. Who rescues the narrator? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: General Lasalle and the French army
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Pit and the Pendulum” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Condemned by the Spanish Inquisition in Toledo, the narrator wakes in a pitch-dark cell. He narrowly avoids falling into a central pit, then wakes strapped beneath a razor-edged pendulum descending toward his heart. He smears food on his bonds so rats chew them free. The walls then glow red-hot and close in, forcing him toward the pit, until a French army takes Toledo and General Lasalle catches…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Pit and the Pendulum”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Pit and the Pendulum” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!” What does “avalanche” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain.
10. Reread: “The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.” What does “charnel” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: charnel: a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Pit and the Pendulum” suggest about reason struggling against terror? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason.
2. Find one example of imagery in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
3. How does the structure in this story shape what we understand about reason struggling against terror? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. In the passage that begins “Very suddenly there came back to my soul motion and sound—the tumultuous motion of the heart, and, in my ears, the sound of its beating.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Pit and the Pendulum”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Condemned by the Spanish Inquisition in Toledo, the narrator wakes in a pitch-dark cell. He narrowly avoids falling into a central pit, then wakes strapped beneath a razor-edged pendulum descending toward his heart. He smears food on his bonds so rats chew them free. The walls then glow red-hot and…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Pit and the Pendulum” set up that the rest of The Pit and the Pendulum will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “When you are afraid, what helps you think clearly?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does point of view appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with terror and endurance? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
10. Background: The Spanish Inquisition was ended by Napoleon's forces in 1808, and French troops did occupy Toledo. Poe's details are invented gothic horror, not history. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “It is a sustained study of suspense built through sensory detail and the narrator's attempts to reason.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Pit and the Pendulum" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about reason struggling against terror? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Pit and the Pendulum": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to the mind under torture: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the imagery in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Pit and the Pendulum" treats reason struggling against terror with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Pit and the Pendulum see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve terror and endurance? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about reason struggling against terror? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Imagery:** look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know

Chapter quiz

1. Who has condemned the narrator?

   A. A king

   B. A pirate captain

   C. A rival family

   D. The Inquisition

2. How does the narrator first discover the pit?
   A. A guard shows him
   B. He trips and falls with his face at its edge
   C. He hears water drip
   D. He sees it by torchlight
3. How does he escape the pendulum?
   A. He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them
   B. He stops the gear
   C. He breaks the chains
   D. A guard frees him
4. What do the walls do?
   A. Collapse
   B. Glow red-hot and close in
   C. Flood with water
   D. Turn to glass
5. Who rescues the narrator?
   A. His brother
   B. A priest
   C. General Lasalle and the French army
   D. The rats' owner
6. In the line “I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?
   A. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   B. dark underground prison cells
   C. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited
   D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
7. In the line “The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.”, what does “charnel” most nearly mean?
   A. dark underground prison cells
   B. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   C. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   D. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited

Answer key: 1. D (The Inquisition); 2. B (He trips and falls with his face at its edge); 3. A (He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them); 4. B (Glow red-hot and close in); 5. C (General Lasalle and the French army); 6. D (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain); 7. D (a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Pit and the Pendulum,” how does Poe show reason struggling against terror? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the imagery you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In The Pit and the Pendulum, how does Poe develop the idea of reason struggling against terror? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the imagery in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Pit and the Pendulum develops the idea of reason struggling against terror. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (where it begins, turns and ends) and its imagery shape the reader's understanding of reason struggling against terror. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Pit and the Pendulum suggests about reason struggling against terror. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's imagery and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses imagery in The Pit and the Pendulum to complicate the reader's understanding of reason struggling against terror. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Pit and the Pendulum within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of reason struggling against terror responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Pit and the Pendulum alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of reason struggling against terror follows or bends those conventions, using the imagery as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Pit and the Pendulum and its treatment of reason struggling against terror. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's imagery and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Pit and the Pendulum as evidence for a larger claim about reason struggling against terror in The Pit and the Pendulum. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Pit and the Pendulum as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of reason struggling against terror. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Pit and the Pendulum.

SAT-style questions

1. *Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a whisper.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “dungeons” most nearly mean?

   A. finding out for certain

   B. dark underground prison cells

   C. surrounded

   D. a stopping

2. *Very suddenly there came back to my soul motion and sound—the tumultuous motion of the heart, and, in my ears, the sound of its beating. Then a pause in which all is blank. Then again sound, and motion, and touch—a tingling sensation pervading my frame. Then the mere consciousness of existence, without thought—a condition which lasted long. Then, very suddenly, thought, and shuddering terror, and earnest endeavor to comprehend my true state. Then a strong desire to lapse into insensibility. Then a rushing revival of soul and a successful effort to move. And now a full memory of the trial, of the judges, of the sable draperies, of the sentence, of the sickness, of the swoon. Then entire forgetfulness of all that followed; of all that a later day and much earnestness of endeavor have enabled me vaguely to recall.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Pit and the Pendulum”?

   A. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

   B. Science that poisons love

   C. Reason struggling against terror

   D. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

SAT key: 1. B (dark underground prison cells); 2. C (Reason struggling against terror)

Whole-book test

The Pit and the Pendulum: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Who has condemned the narrator?
   A. A king
   B. A pirate captain
   C. A rival family
   D. The Inquisition
2. How does the narrator first discover the pit?
   A. A guard shows him
   B. He trips and falls with his face at its edge
   C. He hears water drip
   D. He sees it by torchlight
3. How does he escape the pendulum?
   A. He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them
   B. He stops the gear
   C. He breaks the chains
   D. A guard frees him
4. What do the walls do?
   A. Collapse
   B. Glow red-hot and close in
   C. Flood with water
   D. Turn to glass
5. Who rescues the narrator?
   A. His brother
   B. A priest
   C. General Lasalle and the French army
   D. The rats' owner
6. In the line “I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?
   A. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   B. dark underground prison cells
   C. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited
   D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

7. In the line “The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition of the monks has given rise.”, what does “charnel” most nearly mean?
   A. dark underground prison cells
   B. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   C. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   D. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited
8. As used in the story (“I might as well have attempted to arrest an avalanche!”), what does “avalanche” mean?
   A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   B. cause to start burning
   C. surrounded
   D. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited
9. As used in the story (“The entire surface of this metallic enclosure was rudely daubed in all the hideous and repulsive devices to which the charnel superstition o”), what does “charnel” mean?
   A. prickling or stinging slightly
   B. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited
   C. finding out for certain
   D. dark underground prison cells
10. As used in the story (“Of the dungeons there had been strange things narrated—fables I had always deemed them—but yet strange, and too ghastly to repeat, save in a”), what does “dungeons” mean?
    A. a heavy rain
    B. a stopping
    C. dark underground prison cells
    D. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
11. As used in the story (“At length it forced—it wrestled its way into my soul—it burned itself in upon my shuddering reason.”), what does “wrestled” mean?
    A. surrounded
    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    C. cause to start burning
    D. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
12. As used in the story (“The glare from the enkindled roof illumined its inmost recesses.”), what does “enkindled” mean?
    A. cause to start burning
    B. finding out for certain
    C. a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited
    D. prickling or stinging slightly

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how terror and endurance develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how the mind under torture develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how rescue and hope develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (terror and endurance, the mind under torture, rescue and hope) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (The Inquisition); 2. B (He trips and falls with his face at its edge); 3. A (He rubs food on his straps so rats gnaw them); 4. B (Glow red-hot and close in); 5. C (General Lasalle and the French army); 6. D (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain); 7. D (a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited); 8. A (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain); 9. B (a vault or building where corpses or bones are deposited); 10. C (dark underground prison cells); 11. D (combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force); 12. A (cause to start burning)

Essay assignments

Essay: Terror and endurance

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Pit and the Pendulum teaches about terror and endurance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops terror and endurance across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of terror and endurance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of terror and endurance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Pit and the Pendulum's treatment of terror and endurance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum. Name your

critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on terror and endurance in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The mind under torture

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Pit and the Pendulum teaches about the mind under torture. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the mind under torture across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the mind under torture. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the mind under torture, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Pit and the Pendulum's treatment of the mind under torture in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the mind under torture in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Rescue and hope

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Pit and the Pendulum teaches about rescue and hope. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops rescue and hope across The Pit and the Pendulum. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Pit and the Pendulum (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of rescue and hope. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Pit and the Pendulum (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of rescue and hope, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Pit and the Pendulum's treatment of rescue and hope in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on rescue and hope in The Pit and the Pendulum, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.